

Ukraine: Distrust in institutions grows domestically and abroad

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【メール原文】

In yet another corruption scandal, Ukraine's former prosecutor general, Ruslan Kravchenko, accused Semen Kryvonos, head of the National Anti-Corruption Bureau of Ukraine (NABU), of illegal conduct and graft. Kravchenko, who resigned last week amid a NABU corruption probe into his office, has now left Ukraine on a controversially timed trip.

Quick take

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New scandal deepens distrust in Ukraine's institutions domestically and abroad

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

What Happened

In yet another corruption scandal, Ukraine's former prosecutor general, Ruslan Kravchenko, accused Semen Kryvonos, head of the National Anti-Corruption Bureau of Ukraine (NABU), of illegal conduct and graft. Kravchenko, who resigned last week amid a NABU corruption probe into his office, has now left Ukraine on a controversially timed trip.

Our Take

The episode will further erode trust in Ukraine's institutions. The allegations against the prosecutor general do not directly implicate President Volodymyr Zelensky's inner circle in the way earlier corruption cases did. Zelensky had moved quickly to distance himself from the now disgraced Kravchenko and call for his replacement. Those steps will likely shield Zelensky personally from much of the fallout from the latest developments.

At the same time, the affair will reinforce a broader perception of corruption and mismanagement across state bodies. NABU's investigation reportedly centered on a network tied to the prosecutor general's office that collected kickbacks from call-center financial scams, making the allegations especially egregious and easy to communicate to a broad audience.

For Zelensky, the scandal could also temporarily ease pressure on figures close to him by shifting attention toward the wider government. Over time, however, a growing perception that the entire government is dysfunctional could strengthen support for new political faces.

Kravchenko's claims could discredit NABU's leadership. Kravchenko's response is one of the most prominent recent instances of a disgraced top official hitting back against NABU with counter accusations. If Kravchenko provides further details about Kryvonos or other anticorruption figures, he could damage the agency's credibility. If that narrative takes hold, it could blunt the political effect of NABU's investigations. Even then, replacing Kryvonos with an untainted figure would help to limit the damage, as most of the public still supports the anticorruption agencies and their work.

Perceptions that Zelensky seeks to undermine NABU are the main political risk for the president. Zelensky is unlikely to make an open attempt to neuter the anticorruption agencies using this scandal because he is conscious of the potential political fallout.

Still, perceptions that Zelensky is indirectly targeting the anticorruption agencies could grow if NABU and the Specialized Anti-Corruption Prosecutor's Office (SAPO) produce evidence of a broader campaign to weaken the anticorruption agencies. The two bodies made that claim during last summer's clash over NABU and SAPO's independence and repeated it at a briefing Monday. Any suggestions that Zelensky's office might have coordinated the current attack on NABU with the prosecutor general could also be damaging. Either development would further erode Zelensky's credibility and counteract any reputational damage against NABU.

Skepticism about Ukraine's accession to the EU will harden. Against the backdrop of a series of corruption scandals implicating senior officials and figures close to the president, a new high-profile clash between the former prosecutor general and the anticorruption bodies will reinforce doubts in some European capitals about Ukraine's institutions. Those doubts could complicate Ukraine's path toward deeper integration and, ultimately, membership-level influence in the EU.

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